private in nature. The unauthorized leakage of the tapes, as well as the publication of the transcripts, amounted to a breach of his privacy.

There was, however, more trouble in store for Ratan. The Centre for Public Interest Litigation (CPIL), an NGO that had moved the court in September 2010 against the telecom minister alleging large-scale corruption in the 2G spectrum allocation, announced that they would contest Ratan's plea. Prashant Bhushan, the counsel for CPIL, argued: 'These are not private conversations. These are conversations between a lobbyist and her clients … bureaucrats, journalists and ministers. These show glimpses of all kinds of fixing and deal-making and show how the whole ruling establishment functions. There is enormous public interest in putting these tapes out. It is absurd for Mr Tata to say that this is invasion of his privacy.'

Ratan was not cowered. He raised a larger issue of the rights of the citizens of the country. Senior advocate Harish Salve argued the case in court, stating that even if public figures discussed 'matters of "public importance"; the same … [did] not give carte blanche to the media to publish' their conversations, 'regardless from whichever source' they had 'been received'. On 2 December 2010, Ratan's case came up for hearing.

He asserted that the government had a solemn duty to ensure that the '… agencies who have the authority to tap phones for the purposes of investigation or to establish evidence of law-breaking, also have a responsibility to preserve the privacy of all citizens (other than those who are deemed to be guilty) and not convey this government property to vested interests for publicity seeking and sensationalizing these conversations through the media'.

He demanded that those who were responsible for the leaks be held accountable. At the same time, he appealed to direct the government to keep confidential the remaining 5,000-plus hours of recording, out of which only a fraction had been leaked.

Acknowledging that the issue was important enough to be adjudicated, the Supreme Court also issued a notice to the Union government, the CBI and the two magazines that had released the audio transcripts, seeking their reply in ten days to Ratan's contentions. As the tapes were already in the public domain, the only option left was to ban further publication of the conversations.

Ratan stoutly defended himself outside the courts too. When the telecom-entrepreneur-turned-Rajya-Sabha-member Rajeev Chandrasekhar targeted